

Session 24: Repeated Words and Literary Design

Key Takeaways

- The message of the text is bound up with its literary form, and the literary form is part of the message.
- Like biblical poetry, biblical narrative is intentionally designed with an identifiable structure.
- Although it might not be helpful for everyone, for some, studying the literary design of Bible passages can be exactly what they need in their journey of reading and understanding the Bible.

God's Covenant with Abram: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 12:1-3

The biblical authors use repetition to package the information of a narrative in multiple layers of interconnection. They use the same techniques for Hebrew poetry.

8 **And Elohim said to Noah** and to his sons **with him**, saying,

9 "And I myself, behold, **I set up my covenant with y'all,**
and with your seed after you;

10 and **with every living creature** that is **with you**,
the birds, the beasts, and every **living creature** of the land **with you**;
from everything that comes out of the ark,
even every **living creature** of the land.

11 And **I set up my covenant with y'all**;
and never again will **all flesh** be cut off by the waters of the flood,
and never again will there be a flood to ruin the land."

12 **And Elohim said**,

"This is **the sign of the covenant** which I am giving
between me and between you
and between every living creature that is **with you**, for everlasting generations;

13 I give **my bow in the cloud**,
and it will be for **a sign of a covenant**
between me and between the land;

14 and it will come about when **I cloud a cloud** over the land,
 that **it will be seen**, **the bow in the cloud**,
 15 and **I will remember** my covenant,
 which is **between me and between you**
and between every living creature of all flesh;
and never again will the waters become a flood to ruin all flesh.

16 And **the bow is in the cloud**,
 then **I will see it**,
 to remember **the everlasting covenant**
between Elohim and between every living creature,
 with all flesh that is on the land."

17 **And Elohim said to Noah**,

"This is **the sign of the covenant which I have set up**
between me and all flesh that is on the land."

Genesis 9:8-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

God's speech is designed with the features of Hebrew poetry. The symmetrically paired elements illuminate each other and deepen the significance through similarity and difference.

- Sources of identity: one's land // one's family
- Signs of blessing: great nation // great name
- Signs of divine protection: blessing // curse

The final sentence is also offset by its lack of a symmetrical partner, identifying it as a climactic statement.

Literary Design of 2 Kings 4:1-7

First, let's read the text and use color patterns to register all of the key repeated words.

Woman to Prophet Conflict: Death and Debt

A 1 Now **a certain woman** of the wives of the sons of the prophets **cried out to Elisha**,
 a "Your servant my husband is **dead**,
 b' and you know that **your servant** feared Yahweh;
 c and **the lender** has come to take my **two children** to be his slaves."

Man/Woman Dialogue: He Said She Said

- B
- a 2 **And Elisha said to her,**
 b “What shall I do for you? Tell me, what do you have in the house?”
 a' **And she said,**
 b' “Your maidservant has nothing in the house except a **jar of oil**.”

Command: Get Empty Vessels, Pour Out Until Full

- C
- 3 And he said,
 “Go, request for yourself **vessels** from outside,
 from all your neighbors,
 empty **vessels** ;
 do not get a few.
 4 “And **you shall go in and shut the door behind you and your sons** ,
 and you shall **pour out** into all these **vessels** ,
 and you shall set aside **what is full** .”

Fulfillment: Empty Vessels Poured Out Until Full

- C'
- 5 And **she went from him and shut the door behind her and her sons** ;
 they were bringing to her and **she was pouring** .
 6 And it came about when the **vessels** **were full** ,

Man/Woman Dialogue: She Said He Said

- B'
- a **and she said to her son,**
 b “Bring near to me **another vessel** .”
 a' **And he said to her,**
 b' “There is not **another vessel** .”
 c And **the oil** stopped.

Woman to Man of God Resolution: Life and Debt Paid

- A'
- 7 And **she came and she told the man of God** ,
 and he said,
 “Go, sell **the oil** and pay **your lender** ,
 and you and **your sons** can **live** on the rest.”

2 Kings 4:1-7. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

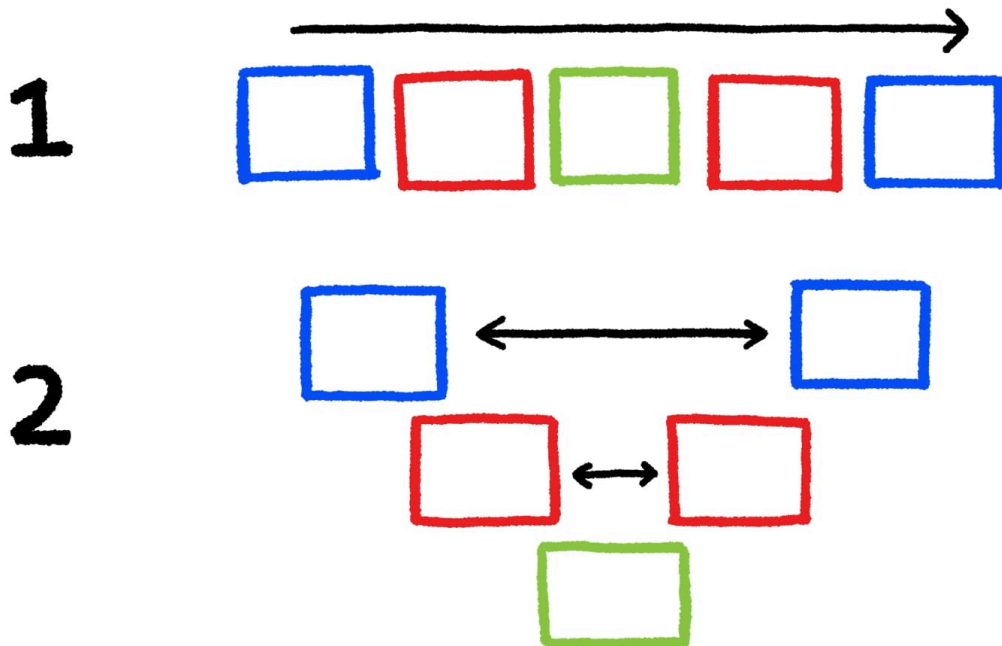
The story seems like a jumble of repetition, but the main themes and the plot arc of the story are clear. The woman's situation changes from death and debt into life and abundance, all because she obeys the word of the prophet. However, if the reader ponders (and memorizes) the story, reciting it and breaking it down into its smallest literary units, the repetitions fall into a sophisticated literary arrangement.

Reading in Two Dimensions

When the reader pays attention to the narrative sequence and the repetitions, it becomes clear that the story has a symmetrical shape made up of both key words and plot/character elements (all indicated in the right column).

The reader is invited to read the story in two dimensions (just like biblical poetry). The story can be read (1) in a forward linear sequence and also (2) in a non-linear symmetrical sequence.

DIFFERENT WAYS OF READING



Different Ways of Reading. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Just as in Hebrew poetry, each corresponding part of the narrative invites the reader to compare and contrast matching scenes as though they were matching parallel lines. When the reader juxtaposes parallel scenes, certain details become more significant.

- The story moves from death (A) to life (A') and from potential slavery (A) to freedom (A'). These are important coordinated images drawn from the exodus narrative where death and slavery are the opposite of life and liberation.
- The key agent who turns death into life is the word of the prophet, who is called "the prophet" (A) and "the man of God" (A').
- The word of God through the prophet creates a test of faith for the woman. Will she trust that God can provide oil (an agricultural staple) out of nothing (B and B')?
- The woman's home and jars change from empty (C) to full (C') because of her trust in God's power.

This story is about how the word of God, through the prophets, can turn death into life and create abundance out of nothing if only God's people will trust him as creator.

Genesis 39: A Complex Example

- a ¹ Now Joseph had been taken down to Egypt;
b and Potiphar bought him:
c an officer of Pharaoh,
c' **the captain (שר)** of the bodyguard,
c'' an Egyptian man (איש מצרי)
b' from **the hand** of the Ishmaelites,
a' who had taken him down there.

- a ² And **Yahweh was with Joseph**,
b so he became a **successful man (איש מצליח)**.
c And he was in **the house** of his master the Egyptian.
a' ³ And his master saw that **Yahweh was with him**
b' and how **everything that he did (כל אשר הוא עשה)** **Yahweh made successful (מצליח)** in **his hand**.
c' ⁴ And Joseph found **favor in his eyes (חן בעיניו)** and he attended him,
and he appointed him over **his house**, and **everything that was his (כל יש לו)**, he gave into **his hand**.

⁵ And it came about when he appointed him in **his house** and over **everything that was his (כל אשר יש לו)**,

Yahweh blessed the Egyptian's house on account of Joseph; thus Yahweh's blessing was upon **everything that was his (כל אשר יש לו)**, in the house and in the field.

⁶ So **he abandoned (עזב)** **everything that was his (כל אשר יש לו)** in **the hand** of Joseph;
and he did not know anything with him, except the food which he ate.
And Joseph was beautiful of form and beautiful of sight.

⁷ And it came about after these things

- a **and his master's wife lifted her eyes toward Joseph and said, "Lie with me."** ⁸ **And he refused**
and he said to his master's wife,
b "Behold, my master does not know, with me, what is in **the house**,
and **everything that is his (כל אשר יש לו)** he has given into **my hand**.
c ⁹ There is no one **greater** in **the house** than me,
and **he has withheld nothing from me** except you, because you are his wife.
b' And how could I do this **great** evil and sin against God?"
a' ¹⁰ **And it came about as she spoke to Joseph day after day,**
he did not listen to her to lie with her, to be with her.

11 And it came about on this day
that he went into **the house** to do his work, and no man from the men of **the house** was there in **the house**.

b 12 And she seized him by **his garment**, saying, "Lie with me!"
And **he abandoned (עזב)** **his garment** in **her hand** and fled, and went outside .

b' 13 And it came about when she saw
that **he abandoned (עזב)** **his garment** in **her hand** and had fled outside ,

a' 14 then she called to the men of her house
and she said to them, "Look, **he has brought in a Hebrew to us to make fun of us**; he came
in to me to lie with me, and **I cried out with a great voice** . 15 And when he heard that I
c raised my voice and cried out, **he abandoned (עזב)** **his garment** beside me **and fled and went outside** ."

a" 16 So she rested his garment beside her until his master came to **his house**.
17 And she spoke to him with these words, "The **Hebrew slave, whom you brought to us,**
c' **came in to me to make fun of me**; 18 and as **I raised my voice and cried out** , then **he abandoned (עזב)** **his garment beside me and fled outside** ."

19 And it came about when his master listened to the words of his wife,
which she spoke to him, saying, "This is what your slave did to me," his anger burned hot.

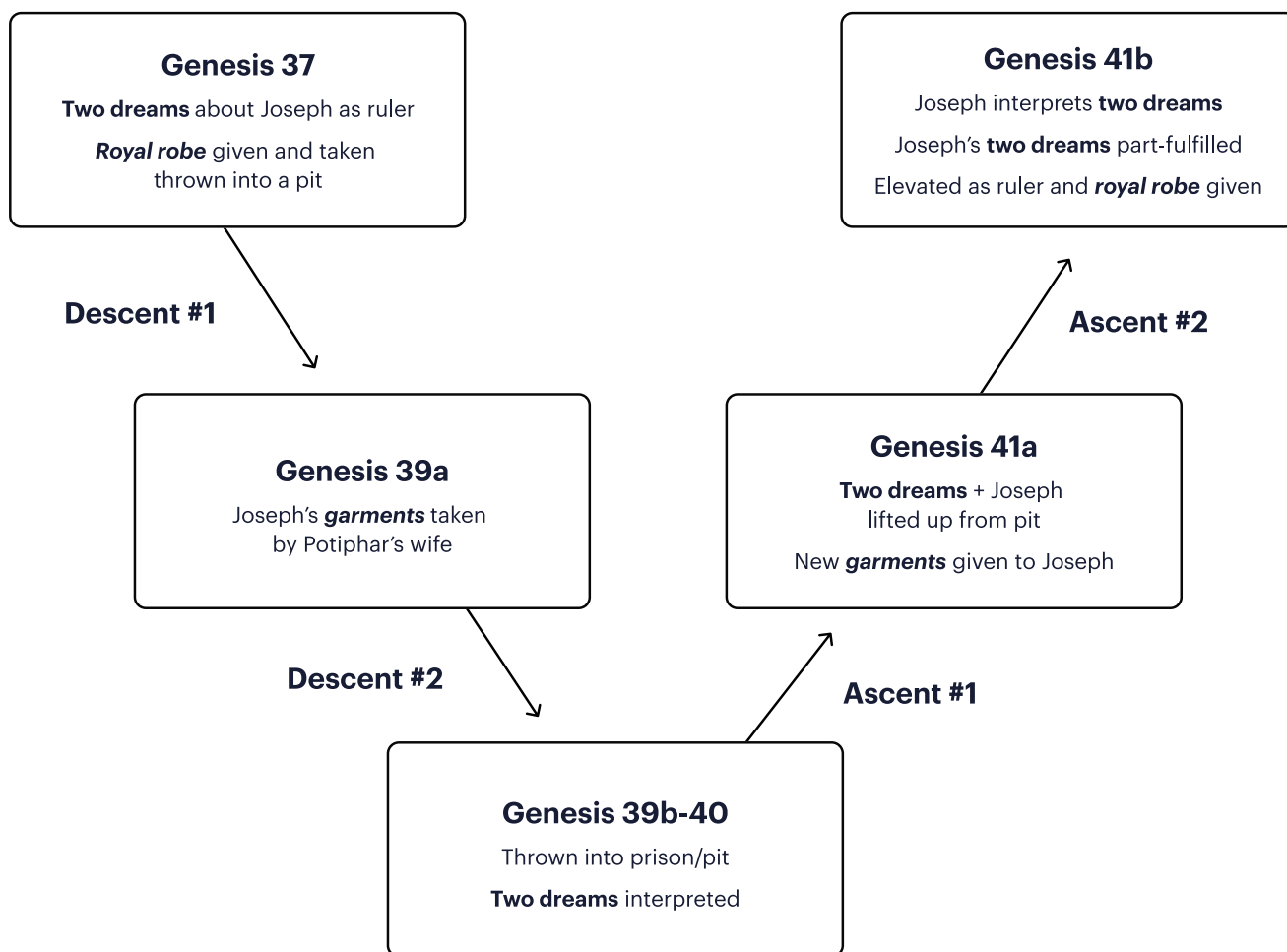
20 And Joseph's master took him and gave him into **the house** of the prison, where the king's prisoners were.

a 21 And **Yahweh was with Joseph** and extended kindness to him,
and gave him **favor in the eyes (חן בעיניו)** of the **captain (שר)** of **the house** of prison.

22 The **captain (שר)** of **the house** of prison gave into **the hand** of Joseph all the prisoners in **the house** of the prison,
b and **everything they were doing, he was doing (כל אשר עשים...הוא עשה)** .

b' 23 The **captain (שר)** of **the house** of prison did not see anything in **his hand**
a' in as much as **Yahweh was with him** , and **whatever he was doing (אשר הוא עשה)** , **Yahweh made it successful (מצליח)** .

Genesis 39. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).



The Role of the Garment in the Joseph Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Reflection Question

What are some pros and cons of breaking passages down according to their structures? What does it help you see?